and assumed everything would be fine, and carried on, and effectively dodged the core issue. In Belfast, at long last, helped by Jacques, I confronted the problem.

Even though I had been playing international cricket for two-and-a-half years, even though I had scored centuries in Tests and one-day internationals, I did not really know how to defend.

From my school days at Affies through my debut for South Africa and on to a life on the treadmill of international cricket, there had never seemed any time to learn, never time to undertake any formal education in the basic skills of the game. For as long as I could remember, it had seemed enough for me to try to hit almost every ball either to or over the boundary, seemed enough for me to attack and play strokes.

In Belfast, in June 2007, it was no longer enough.

Working with Kallis, one on one in the nets, we looked at my grip and my backlift. We looked at the position of my head and studied the transfer of my weight when I played back or forward. Hour after hour, as he threw balls at me and offered advice, we began to construct a proper defensive technique.

The Proteas played three one-day internationals in Zimbabwe during August 2007 and the hard work began to pay dividends as I scored 63, 0 not out and 107 in an encouraging 3–0 series win. The transformation was not complete but a process had been started, and at least now there was hope of better times to come.

We returned home to compete as the host team in the inaugural ICC World Twenty20 tournament, hopeful that, with a little luck, we could finally win an official ICC limited-overs event. Twelve national teams arrived in the country, providing plenty of entertainment in a frenetic 13-day schedule ...

The Wanderers is packed for the opening match between South Africa and the West Indies, and very soon it looks as though Chris Gayle is